

CHAPTER FIVE

THE SECRETS OF TEXTS: ESOTERIC HERMENEUTICS

De Creatione mundi factâ per conversiones & rotationes literarum.

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The Readability of the Cosmos: Europe's Obsession with Words

Looking at the influence of the so-called 'life sciences' in contemporary Western societies, one cannot but wonder whether we are indeed opening a new chapter in the history of science: what used to be the deterministic paradigm of physics has been transformed into a dynamic paradigm of 'life,' in which ecology, biology, and genetics play a decisive role. In fact, the influence of these disciplines is so strong that it exerts its impact on various other domains of modern societies. Metaphors of coding and decoding have captured the imagination of a wide public—from the *Bible Code* to the *Da Vinci Code*—and are also part and parcel of genetic language.

That the DNA chromosomes are to be described as a 'code' is not self-evident. Among the first scholars who used this metaphor for the smallest units of human life was the famous mathematician Erwin Schrödinger. In 1927 he said:

It is these chromosomes, or probably only an axial skeleton fibre of what we actually see under the microscope as the chromosome, that contain in some kind of code-script the entire pattern of the individual's future development and of its functioning in the mature state. Every complete set of chromosomes contains the full code [...].¹

When Marshall Nirenberg and Heinrich Matthaei at the *National Institutes of Health* in Bethesda (USA) succeeded in explaining the correlation between the bases of the nucleic acid and the amino acids in proteins—a problem known as the 'problem of molecular coding'—this scientific breakthrough quickly entered the fields of literature and

¹ Schrödinger, *What is Life*, 20.